



Model Bee Village Scheme: Sweet Success through Sustainable Stingless Beekeeping

Amala, U^{1*}, Venu, H. S², Manjunatha, C³, Subaharan, K⁴ and Sushil, S. N⁵.

^{1*}Senior Scientist (Entomology), ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources, Hebbal, Bengaluru 560064, Karnataka.

²Junior Research Fellow, ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources, Hebbal, Bengaluru 560064, Karnataka.

³Scientist, ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources, Hebbal, Bengaluru 560064, Karnataka.

⁴Principal Scientist, ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources, Hebbal, Bengaluru 560064, Karnataka.

⁵Director, ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources, Hebbal, Bengaluru 560064, Karnataka.

The "Model Bee Village Scheme" is a concept under India's larger "Sweet Revolution" initiative, primarily implemented through the central government's National Beekeeping and Honey Mission (NBHM) and the Khadi and Village Industries Commission's (KVIC) Honey Mission Programme. This Model Bee Village Scheme was funded by National Bee Board, New Delhi. The core idea is to promote scientific beekeeping in specific, potential-rich areas (villages/blocks/districts) to generate income and employment in rural areas, enhance agricultural productivity through pollination, and boost honey production and export.

The objectives of the scheme were,

- **Income & Employment Generation:** To provide supplementary livelihood support to farmers, landless labourers, tribal communities, women and unemployed youth through beekeeping.
- **Enhance Crop Yield:** To leverage the crucial role of bees in cross-pollination, thereby improving the yield and quality of various horticultural and agricultural crops (fruits, vegetables, pulses, oilseeds, etc.).
- **Scientific Beekeeping:** To transition from traditional practices to scientific beekeeping methods by providing training, equipment and technical support.
- **Infrastructure Development:** To establish necessary infrastructure like Integrated Beekeeping Development Centres (IBDCs), honey processing plants, quality control labs, and storage facilities.
- **Market Linkages:** To ensure beekeepers get fair prices for their produce by formalizing market linkages and promoting collective approaches like Self-Help Groups (SHGs) and Farmer Producer Organizations (FPOs).

Mode of operation of Bee village scheme,

The scheme is implemented with a focused approach in specific areas/villages/clusters, allowing for better resource allocation and monitoring. Key activities include:

- **Identification of Beneficiaries:** Potential beekeepers, farmers, SHGs, and NGOs are identified, with preference often given to SC/ST, women and BPL categories.
- **Training & Capacity Building:** Beneficiaries receive comprehensive training on scientific beekeeping, beehive management, honey extraction and disease control.
- **Input Support:** Participants are provided with essential inputs, often at a subsidized rate, such as bee boxes, live bee colonies and beekeeping toolkits (smoker, bee veil, knife, etc.).
- **Financial Assistance:** The scheme often facilitates access to credit (bank loans) and provides subsidies for setting up apiaries.
- **Technical & Handholding Support:** Continuous technical guidance and support are provided by designated agencies (like KVIC, NABARD, State Horticulture Departments).
- **Processing and Marketing:** The program helps with post-harvest management, including processing, branding, and establishing market tie-ups to ensure effective sale of honey and other beehive products (beeswax, bee pollen, propolis, royal jelly, etc.).

The scheme is designed to create a holistic ecosystem for beekeeping, ensuring sustainability and profitability for participants while also benefiting the environment and broader agriculture sector through enhanced pollination.



ICAR-National Bureau of Agricultural Insect Resources (NBAIR), Bengaluru initiatives on promotion of ‘Stingless bee village’ concept for sustainable beekeeping

Stingless bees, an ideal candidate for ‘Model Bee village concept’,

Stingless bees, *Tetragonula* spp.(Apidae: Hymenoptera), are eusocial corbiculate bees and are reported to be the essential pollinators of crops like coconut, sunflower and gourds and greenhouse cultivated sweet pepper. They construct perennial colonies in the cavities of old walls of abandoned buildings, tree cavities, termite mounds and concealed places. There are several advantages of stingless bees,

- High value honey production
- Constructs perennial colonies
- No absconding behaviour
- Honey is widely used in medicinal and ayurvedic preparations

ICAR-NBAIR, Bengaluru promoted ‘Stingless bee village concept’ in the tribal areas of Chamarajanagar district, Karnataka

Keeping all the advantages of Stingless bees, ICAR-NBAIR, Bengaluru has taken strenuous efforts with the funding of National Bee Board (NBB), New Delhi has launched a project on ‘Development of Stingless Bee village in the tribal regions of Chamarajanagar district of Karnataka’.

As a first phase of the programme, 60 tribal women from five tribal villages viz., Kombudakki, Mendare, Indiganatta, Gorasane and Keeranahola were selected. The women were trained for stingless bee keeping practices. The participants were imparted practical training on handling of stingless bee colonies, colony division, identification of queen, drone and workers. The trainees were appraised with necessary information on the seasonal colony management practices, requeening techniques and honey extraction methods. Stingless bee colonies were distributed to the participants.





Hands on Training on Stingless beekeeping to the trainees from the Tribal villages of Chamarajanagar district



Stingless bee colonies distributed to the trainees from the Tribal villages of Chamarajanagar district